

JOKING RELATIONSHIPS IN TANGANYIKA

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THE note on 'Joking relationship in East Africa' in *Africa*, vol. xiii, pp. 170-3, 1940, brought to my notice a custom of which I had never heard. It led me to make inquiries about *utani* among the Africans on my station, whom I found without exception to be ready to discuss the matter. What follows is based on the information given me in Swahili by thirty-two men belonging to the following seventeen tribes:

Yao, Ngoni, Wemba, Ngindo, Nyakyusa, Kinga, Mbunga, Ha, Sumbwa, Nyamwezi, Zaramu, Zigua, Nyiramba, Chagga, Sambaa, Bondei, and Digo.

The first few tribes in this list live in the far south of Tanganyika Territory; the last four are along the north-eastern border; and the lands of the remainder are intermediate. In all of them *utani* was shown to be important; so that it exists in, and binds together, tribes from one end of Tanganyika to the other. As some of my informants mentioned, there is no doubt that under modern influences certain of its manifestations are falling into disuse locally. But I gained the impression that in general *utani* is alive, vigorous, and well understood; and I have evidence that at least certain features of it continue to be observed by both Christians and Mohammedans, even those of considerable fervour.

It is the more surprising that in East Africa it should be so undocumented as would appear from the note mentioned above. I have not been able to make an exhaustive search in the literature, but a number of books and papers in German and in English have been available to me. In these I have been able to find only two references, a casual one (by inference, not by name) in the Culwicks' account of the Bena¹ and a half-page specially devoted to 'the *mtani*' in Dale's description of Bondei customs.² The latter reference, though unsystematic and incomplete, is of special interest now that the tribe has been subjected to forty-five more years of sophisticating influences as powerful as any in Tanganyika. A relationship agreeing in point after point with *utani* has been noted also between certain Bemba clans in Northern Rhodesia who recognize each other as '*banungwe*'.³

The sketch given in the following pages is derived only from a brief and superficial inquiry. I record the results of it because the measure of agreement between my informants gives me confidence that the main outlines are correct, and also in order to show how extensive and interesting a field of inquiry remains to be explored. Leisurely discussion with old tribesmen would be sure to correct, as well as greatly to supplement, the information obtained by me from such sources as happened to be available. I make no attempt to discuss my data, for I am not qualified to do so.

According to Johnson⁴ *utani* is derived from an Arabic root, which may be transliterated *watan*, meaning 'to reside in',⁵ whence in Swahili *watani*, 'a person's

¹ Culwick, A. T. and G. M., *Ubena of the Rivers*, London, 1935.

² Dale, G., 'Account of the Principal Customs and Tribes of the Natives inhabiting the Bondei Country', *J.R.A.I.*, pp. 181-239, 1896.

³ Richards, A. I., 'Reciprocal Clan Relationships among the Bemba of N. Rhodesia', *Man*, xxxvii,

222, pp. 188-93, 1927.

⁴ Johnson, F., *A Standard Swahili-English Dictionary*, London, 1925.

⁵ This seems to be a mistake; other evidence is all to the effect that the Arabic *watan* is a noun, meaning 'home', &c., as in Swahili.

home, native village, country'. The *wa-* has been treated as *ua-* of the U class of noun and by 'back-formation' the verb *tania*, 'to be familiar with, chaff, treat as of very near kin or a very great friend', has been produced. Hence *mtani* is 'one of a family, a kinsman', but an Arab from Zanzibar tells me that to his people the word has no further implications. Among tribesmen of the mainland the word has acquired an intensified meaning, which Johnson indicates in a note that '*watani* can abuse each other, or take each other's things, without there being a quarrel'. In fact, as will appear, the *utani* bond is one of extraordinary power, so that in some respects *watani* are closer than relatives by blood; they have the most far-reaching mutual obligations of hospitality and the sharing of property, they perform special functions at each other's funerals, they have certain quasi-magical powers between themselves, and finally their mutual abuse and horseplay are not merely permissive but almost ritual and are linked with a remarkable system of forfeits.

At the outset of the inquiry it became apparent that *utani* can operate both between tribes and within a tribe. In the former case, which may conveniently be called 'external *utani*', the acknowledgement of *utani* between two tribes means that every member of each tribe is, by birth, and irrespective of age or sex, the *mtani* of every member of the other. 'Internal *utani*', within the same tribe, exists between certain families or clans (*ukoo*) or between certain members of certain families. So far as my evidence goes, the privileges and the obligations of any given man's *watani* appear as a rule—though by no means always—to be the same whether they belong to his own tribe or to another; nevertheless it is somewhat surprising that the word *utani* should be applied to both the 'external' and the 'internal' relationship. It is noteworthy also that the word *utani*, presumably of Arabic derivation, is in familiar use by all the tribes I have investigated, and only in Yao have I been able to obtain any tribal equivalent for it.

It is said that among the Zaramu a stranger claiming to be an *mtani* of yours can be tested by getting him to pluck leaves from some vegetable growing in your plantation. If he truly is an *mtani* the plant will die; if he is not it will continue to live.

External 'utani' ties

Fifteen of the seventeen tribes investigated claim external *utani* as follows:

Yao¹ with Ngoni, Langulu, and Potola (the last two in Southern Nyasaland).

Ngoni with Yao, Wemba, Ngindo, Nyakyusa, Kinga, Bena, Makonde, Mwera, Mbunga, Ha, Nyamwezi, Sukuma, Hehe, Kami, Luguru, Gogo, Nyiramba, Zaramu.

Wemba (Tanganyika outliers of the Bemba of Northern Rhodesia) with Ngoni, Hehe, Yao, and Ngindo.

Ngindo with Ngoni (and some Nyasa tribes).

Kinga with Ngoni, Hehe, Bena, and Pangwa.

Nyakyusa with Ngoni (especially), Sangu, Hehe, and Gogo.

Mbunga with Yao (one branch), Ngoni, Pogoro, Makonde, Rufiji, Mawia, Kinga, Nyika, Hehe, Sangu, Gogo, Sagara, Vidunda, Kami, and Zaramu.

Ha with Ngoni and certain Nyamwezi.

¹ The Yao informant was born in Nyasaland. It is probable that the Tanganyika Yao would have some different ties of *utani*.

Sumbwa (often regarded as Nyamwezi by distant tribes) with Ngoni, Gogo, Zaramu, Zigua.

Nyamwezi with Ngoni, Gogo, Kami, Kaguru, Sagara, Zaramu, and Zigua.

Zaramu with Ngoni, Mbunga, Nyamwezi, Sukuma, Zigua, Digo, and Doe.

Zigua with Nyamwezi, Sukuma, Kami, Luguru, Hehe, Gogo, and Zaramu.

Nyiramba with Masai, Mbulu, Mangati, Mbugwe, Nyaturu, Gogo, and certain of the Nyamwezi.

Digo with Zaramu, Kami, and Luguru.

Chagga with Pare. (Pare are said to have *utani* also with Teita.)

Each informant was asked how he thought external *utani* had originated. Without exception he said that his ancestors had fought (*pigana*) with the tribe with whom he now has *utani*. This is completely at variance with the reports that the 'joking relationships' of the French Sudan owe their origin to acts of legendary clemency.¹ I can only infer, for it was never explicit, that in Tanganyika *utani* was a condition or a consequence of peace-making. But how fundamental the necessity of past enmity seems to be is illustrated by two remarks. Nyiramba: 'The Irangi wanted *utani* with us but we refused because we had not fought with them.' A Nyamwezi expressed surprise on hearing that the Masai had *utani* with the Nyiramba and added: 'I suppose they must have fought together.' Moreover, speaking of the 'extraordinarily cordial relations said by the Bena to exist now between them and the Ngoni'—which are obviously the *utani* relations recorded above on Ngoni information—the Culwicks call it 'an affection based on the mutual regard of old well-known, well-tried opponents'. But 'other one-time foes such as the Wapogoro are regarded with contempt as having "no strength"'. This agrees with the impression I had from my Ngoni informant who emphatically denied a suggestion that the Pogoro might be *watani* of his. Actually the Pogoro preferred the poisoned arrow from ambush to the hand-to-hand encounter (*ibid.*, p. 168).

It does not appear that the enmity necessarily took the form of organized warfare: to the country they passed through, trading caravans could be hardly less of a scourge than organized raids. (Zigua: 'In the time of our fathers the Nyamwezi going to Pangani chased us with guns and took us and sold us to the Arabs.') If Tanganyika *utani* really has the basis suggested, then the most aggressive tribes and also the most itinerant would be expected to have the most numerous ties of *utani*. To some extent this is true: no tribe has more than the Ngoni, who in the years following 1840 raided from the Nyasa region north to Victoria Nyanza and east to the Indian Ocean.² At least three of the tribes on the Ngoni list, the Kami, Luguru, and Zaramu would not, however, from the known Ngoni movements, have been expected to come in contact with them, and since the Ngoni seem never to have been porters on a large scale it is not easy to understand how these particular ties of *utani* can have been based on former enmity. The Nyamwezi, on the other hand, have been the great porter tribe of East Africa and, except the Ngoni, all the tribes with which they themselves claim *utani* are those whose territories are crossed by the caravan routes to Pangani and Bagamoyo. Perhaps, as has been suggested above,

¹ Paulme, D., 'Parenté à plaisanteries et alliance par le sang en Afrique Occidentale', *Africa*, vol. xii, pp. 433-44, 1939.

² Poole, E. H. Lane, *The Native Tribes of the Eastern Province of Northern Rhodesia*, Lusaka, 1938.

they did come into constant collision with these tribes nearer the coast; but in this connexion it is noteworthy that the Nyiramba, besides having ties showing that the warlike non-Bantu tribes of Tanganyika participate in the *utani* system, also have ties with the Mbugwe. These are a small sedentary people separated from the Nyiramba by the Mbulu group; and it is not likely that they could have had much contact with the Nyiramba but for the fact that the latter pass through Umbugwe to work on the coffee plantations of Arusha. This rather suggests that in some cases *utani* may have originated, not in 'noble' warfare, but as a convenient arrangement by which a tribe secures and regularizes hospitality from a weaker and more sedentary people on whom in the course of its comings and goings it makes frequent demands. In theory the arrangement is entirely reciprocal, but in practice it hardly can be so; for example, the Nyamwezi movement through Zigua or Zaramu country must be vastly greater than the opposite. Relative unfamiliarity with visits from the more sedentary tribe might account for the sort of case mentioned in Pedler's note.¹

It may be remarked that many contiguous tribes are not *watani*. For example, the Zigua have no *utani* with the Nguu or the Sambaa, the reason given being that they are relatives (*ndugu*).

It would be interesting to know the means by which each *utani* tie became established. For example, it is hardly conceivable that any formal peace-making took place between the itinerant Nyamwezi gangs, under Arab leadership, and the loosely organized Zigua on whom they had been accustomed to trample. But however arrived at, it seems likely that the ties of external *utani* recognized to-day are historically very recent. The movement of the Masai southwards is not likely to have brought them into collision with the Nyiramba until about a hundred years ago.² The Ngoni, who own to more ties than any other tribe, did not begin their irruption into Tanganyika until about the same date and are said to have stopped fighting, e.g. with the Nyakyusa, only after European interference, which cannot have been till after about 1880. The harrying of the Zigua by the Nyamwezi caravans probably ceased no earlier than the suppression of the slave trade in the 1870s. A recent origin for external *utani* would go far to explain the general use of an Arabic word for the relationship, but the internal *utani*, next to be discussed, may well be much older.

Internal 'utani'

Of the fifteen tribes whose external *utani* ties are listed above, eight apparently have no internal *utani*; but in the Ngoni, Yao, Nyakyusa, Nyiramba, Zaramu, Zigua, and Digo tribes internal *utani* co-exists with external.³ Two other tribes, the Bondei and Sambaa, have internal *utani* but not external, except that some Bondei recognize rights of mutual hospitality, which are perhaps vestigial, with certain of the Digo. In all these tribes the internal *utani* is hereditary and, except in the Ngoni, there is no suggestion of any way in which new ties can now be formed.

¹ Pedler, F. J., 'Joking Relationship in East Africa', *Africa*, vol. xiii, pp. 170-3, 1940.

² Sandford, G. R., *An Administrative and Political History of the Masai Reserve*, London, 1919.

³ Most probably this applies also to the Bena, for apart from the likelihood that their *mlongo* relation-

ship as described by the Culwicks (1935) is a local form of *utani* there is the very significant statement (*ibid.*, p. 182) that the Tani and Wakinimanga clans are 'on sufficiently intimate terms to indulge in mutual abuse without giving offence'.

None of my informants can say with any confidence how his hereditary internal *utani* originated, but three different men suggest vaguely that the ancestors of the families concerned may have fought (*pigana*) or disputed (*gombana*). It is possible that the still existing method of initiating a new internal *utani* among the Ngoni may have had a wider currency. In that tribe when a death occurs it is an honourable thing for someone neither *mtani* nor relative to offer to dig the grave and carry out the burial. If he is allowed to do so he and his descendants become the *watani* of the bereaved family; the essential qualification seems to be that he should have handled the corpse. The performance of burial duties enters also into the reported origin of the Bemba *banungwe* (Richards, 1937), but as only one, not the essential, qualification.

In most of the nine tribes having internal *utani* every member of a family is the *mtani* of every member of another with which *utani* exists, irrespective of age and sex. But in Nyiramba and in Yao families, members of any given generation cannot acknowledge *utani* until their father and his opposite number in the linked family are both dead; so that *utani* tends to be confined to members of the same generation. Amongst the Nyakyusa the internal *utani* is said to be very narrowly restricted, a person's *watani* being limited to the children of his (or her) father's uterine sisters. The *utani* does not extend to the next generation.

The manner in which internal *utani* is inherited has interesting variants and implications. Among the Ngoni, the Zigua, and the Digo the children of both sexes inherit the *utani* ties of their mother as well as those of their father; in the Yao a boy is said to inherit only his father's *utani*, a girl her mother's. Among the Sambaa and the Bondei children of both sexes follow the father's *utani*, and to a lesser extent the mother's also 'because', as two of my informants remarked, 'the father's is the stronger'. Here a transition may be taking place; for in the Zaramu tribe children of both sexes now inherit only their father's *utani*, whereas it is recalled that in times past they took only their mother's.¹

The extent to which a woman is affected by the *utani* ties of her husband would require an investigation in itself. In the Ngoni if A, *mtani* of B (also Ngoni), marries an Ngoni woman not *mtani* of B, she becomes the *mtani* of B. (But if the three concerned were Bondei this result would not follow.) If the Ngoni A were to marry a Nyamwezi woman, who would by birth be an (external) *mtani* of B, her *utani* with B would be unaffected. But if Ngoni A had married a woman of a tribe with whom the Ngoni have no *utani*, then she would not become the *mtani* of B 'because she would not understand it'. On the other hand a Nyakyusa is of opinion that he would be on *mtani* terms with any woman an *mtani* of his married.

The intermarriage of 'watani'

In general, there is no bar to the marriage of external *watani*; in fact, as will be shown below, a man has often special claims to the daughter of an *mtani*. The only firm objection to external *mtani* marriage comes from my Chagga informant, who holds that it is not a good thing for a Chagga to marry a Pare 'because of the *utani*'

¹ Mrs. Culwick comments that these variations are probably one of the many results of the mix-up of matriliney and patriliney which is so common in

the Tanganyika tribes, with patriliney tending to supervene.

(which there are no means of breaking), though such marriages are not rare. A marriage between external *watani* may, however, retain peculiar features. In the Ha, if married *watani* separate, no claim for the return of the bride-price lies. The Sumbwa hold that, before *watani* actually marry, the *utani* between the bride and her father on one side and the bridegroom on the other should be ceremonially broken with the slaughter of a beast. This is stated to have been adopted as a convenient expedient. The bride's father would not anyway be allowed to 'joke' with his son-in-law after the marriage; he might from force of habit forget this prohibition and then the elders would have fined him no less than five head of cattle. The breaking of *utani* at a cost of one beast thus insures him against a possible loss of five.

Public opinion against the marriage of internal *watani* seems on the whole to be quite strong, although its intensity varies, even between persons of the same tribe. Of the nine tribes listed above as having internal *utani*, only Digo, Bondei, and Zaramu give unreserved approval to such marriages without restriction. In the Ngoni the *utani* is ceremonially broken with the slaughter of a goat, though the same tribe do not think this necessary before external *watani* marry. The Yao and the Bondei would disallow it altogether, some even asserting that the partners would die. It may take place between Nyiramba, but in case of subsequent separation a return of bride-price cannot be claimed. Among Nyakyusa internal *watani*, who must in any case be cross-cousins, it appears that marriage is barred, but a man has the right to give in marriage an *mtani* who is the daughter of his mother's brother.

In this connexion it is noteworthy that in some tribes (e.g. Bondei, Sumbaa, Sumbwa, Digo, Zigua) it is held that a man must not marry the widow of an *mtani*, whether internal or external. Among the Sumbwa, indeed, such a marriage is expected to result in the death of the parties.

As a general rule it appears that on the marriage of *watani* their 'joking relationship'—fairly described as a right to plague each other with impunity—lapses, apparently as a concession to the husband's marital dignity. In the Wemba, however, it is said to persist.

The joking

It cannot be emphasized too strongly that the joking is only one aspect of *utani*, the other being most far-reaching mutual obligations. The joking itself is usually referred to by the Africans under two heads: *tukana* (curse, abuse, revile, insult, call bad names) and *danganya* (elude, delude, deceive, defraud, cheat, beguile, impose upon, belie). In addition there are horseplay, and a remarkable system of forfeits, which merits a separate section. So far as I can gather, all the joking may be done in public, with no restriction of place or time.

Gibes offered by my informants as typical of the *tukana* exchange are the sort of crudities we uttered ourselves when we were very young: 'Yours is a rotten tribe'; 'Baboon yourself'; and so on. A richer insult is: 'You're better dead: I want your wife.' The horseplay takes the form of shoving each other about, or a man can come to the house of his *mtani* and seize his wife, declaring that he is going off with her (Ngoni). All the informants stress the fact that if anyone who was not an *mtani* said and did such things there would be a row. ('You might get angry inside at the insults of your *mtani*, but you must say "it is my *mtani*"': Nyakyusa.) Almost

without exception the view is expressed, however, that between *watani* rudeness is not merely permitted but is the right and the expected thing.

Most informants insist that this ritual applies without distinction of age or sex;¹ and it is a tribute to the power of the *utani* relationship that at least in theory it should override the rule that age should receive respect. (Also only one said in so many words that a man would not chaff a woman as roughly as he would another man.) In this connexion a stock question of mine was: 'Surely a boy *that* high [three feet] wouldn't abuse an old man?' The usual answer was: 'He must (*lazima*) abuse the old man because he is his *mtani*.' Others added: 'The old man could not be angry.' (Cf. Richards (1937): 'it is said that even a commoner may swear at his chief if they are *banungwe*.') A dispenser, a man of some education and local position, replied without hesitation: 'Certainly, a little boy, who is my *mtani*, abuses *me*.' Strongly though this may be held in theory it does not always take place in practice: two or three have said that a small boy would naturally be rather afraid of an old man; and my cook in his twenties (Ngoni), though acknowledging full *utani* with my house-boy of fifty (Zaramu), treats him respectfully.

The deception of a man by his *mtani* as a rule takes the same form as our 'making an April fool'. It is noteworthy, however, that nearly all my informants cited as their prime jest the telling of an *mtani* that his *baba* (father or uncle) had died. This is exactly what is described as 'l'une des plaisanteries "classiques"' in the West African joking relationship (Paulme, 1939). In Tanganyika the fooling is allowed to go its full length: a man may set off with all his family in tears for the scene of the death and he may be allowed to make a fifty-mile journey without being undeceived (Digo, Nyiramba). Or it may take the form of an old man telling a child that its *baba* has died; the child may run howling home, to be laughed at there by its elders for not realizing that its informant was an *mtani* (Bondei). In one tribe, the Nyiramba, with its restricted cousin *utani*, it is held that internal *watani* should not allude to the death of their elders, though their external *watani* may make a jest of it.

It is likely that there may be a whole canon of pleasantries concerned with what is called a 'dirty beard' (*ndevu chafu*). Among the Bondei any *mtani* (male or female) who meets one has a right to pull it. At the other end of the Territory the Nyakyusa face so adorned is liable to be forcibly shaved without water.

In most tribes a man's *watani* put up some special show at his wedding. They may playfully curse the union (Sumbwa); they may block the door of his hut or obstruct the procession (Mbunga, Ngindo, Nyamwezi, Nyiramba, Digo); one of them may pretend to carry off the bride by force (Ngoni, Zigua, Sambaa); or he may get into the bridegroom's bed swearing that the bride shall be his (Zaramu, Zigua, Kinga). On all these occasions the *mtani* has to be bought off with a shilling or two.

Forfeits

(a) Meat carried in the hand, with or without a string, is forfeit unless it is covered with a leaf (of any plant whatever) or a bit of paper. This forfeit is recognized in all the tribes investigated except, perhaps, the Nyiramba. It never applies to ordinary

¹ It is only for verbal convenience that throughout these notes I have used masculine nouns and

pronouns in describing *utani* custom. As a rule they should be taken as referring also to female agents.

food, 'only to something with blood in it' (Ngoni). Among the Zigua it is said to hold good between external, but not between internal, *watani*.

(b) Clothes put on inside out (or, apparently, back to front) are also universally acknowledged to be forfeit.

(c) A garment held up in front to carry some such food as rice is forfeit together with the food, at least in Ngoni, Kinga, Sumbwa, Nyamwezi, and Digo usage. The explanation offered is that the hem of the garment is turned inside out, which would make this forfeit a derivative of (b).

(d) New clothes worn before they have been washed are forfeit, at least among the Nyakyusa, Sumbwa, and Nyamwezi. An explanation is that it is bad luck for the owner to wear them in that condition, because that is how a corpse wears its shroud.

(e) Clothes put out to dry on the roof of a house are held forfeit by most of the tribes, certainly by the Ngoni, Nyakyusa, Kinga, Wemba, Yao, Ngindo, Ha, Zaramu, Sumbwa, Nyamwezi, Digo, and Zigua. (Cf. also Richards, 1937.) Some extend the forfeit to footgear, to headgear, even to a hoe, and to things hung upon a line (Wemba) or on a tree (Zigua). Clothes spread on the ground or bushes seem everywhere to be safe. Both Yao and Wemba informants connect this forfeit with a custom of erecting a hut by the grave of a newly dead chief and covering it with a cloth. The Yao *mtani* taking clothes from a roof will say: 'Why have you spread these out to dry? Has your father died?' The Wemba equivalent is 'I see a chief has died in this house': the Ngoni, 'I see you have put a corpse out to dry'. A Zigua thinks that the basis of the custom may be that it is bad luck for a person to have about his house an object that is like a dead or a hanged man.

(f) An entire brew of beer is mentioned by the Yao, Mbunga, Nyamwezi, Ngoni, and Kinga as forfeit in certain circumstances. Among the Yao, if an *mtani* enters a hut where beer has been prepared and is not offered a drink immediately he can claim the lot. In the other tribes the beer is apparently safe from an *mtani* if it is thoroughly covered with leaves.

In all the forfeits described above the *mtani* takes the initiative and with few exceptions, if any, establishes a claim by spitting on the object concerned. He (or she) then has an indefeasible right to it. If the wearer should be reluctant to give up a forfeited shirt, for example, his *mtani* who has caught him wearing it inside out has a perfect right to tear it off him; and all my informants agree that no action could lie at law for such an act between *watani*. The owner can always, if he wishes, ask to ransom the forfeited article, but the *mtani* has absolute discretion whether he accepts the offer (usually a few cents) or not. An example of a transaction of this nature that has come under my notice is of an Ngoni living in Usambara, who, on a visit to a kinsman at a neighbouring village passed the hut of a Nyamwezi, that is, an external *mtani* of his. The man had left a pair of canvas shoes on his hut roof while he went to market. The Ngoni carried them off with him, making no secret of it. Later, when the owner came back from market and heard what had happened he followed the Ngoni to the relative's house. There, after a bantering discussion, he was allowed to ransom his shoes—for a hen, since he had no money.

It would probably be difficult, if not impossible, really to ascertain what underlies most of these forfeit customs, but from the comments on (d) and (e) I infer that the *mtani* in taking possession of things that have an ill-omened appearance is instru-

mental in saving his friend from possible bad consequences. This impression is much stronger in one other forfeit, which is recognized in practically every tribe examined:

(g) Clothes that have had holes eaten in them by rats. This forfeit has the peculiarity that it is not necessary for the *mtani* to spit on the objects, and as a rule it is explicitly stated that the owner cannot ransom them. The reason for this is indicated by some people's conviction that directly you see a garment of yours has been eaten by rats you must seek out an *mtani* and press it on him (Ngindo; Mbunga; Yao; Nyiramba; Sambaa 'if he is near'). The reasons given by the first four of these tribes are respectively: that if the owner wore such clothes again it would be bad luck (*uchimvi*); that he would be *maskini* ('a hapless, luckless, miserable individual'); that if the clothes were not given to the *mtani* rats would eat the owner's property every day; that such clothes become *mwiko* ('something deliberately abstained from, for considerations of health, taboo, totem'). Clearly in this forfeit the *mtani* is an instrument for removing a load of impending evil.

The extreme bad luck attributed to rats' attentions may possibly have some connexion with the idea of the *vizuu*, 'the spirits of people thought to be dead, but . . . in reality spirited away by magic' and 'employed by witches . . . to enter houses in the form of a rat and kill people by devouring their livers' (Johnson, 1939). But a Sumbwa extends this forfeit to clothes eaten by cockroaches, an Ngoni to those in which holes have accidentally been burnt, the appropriate remark by the *mtani* being: 'You are much too fine a fellow to wear clothes like that.'

The mutual obligations of 'watani'

The essence of *utani* is that every person admitted to it has a right to hospitality from an *mtani*. As enunciated by all my informants, any man can enter the hut of an *mtani*, and can eat and drink his fill with or without invitation—cf. Dale op. cit. It seems certainly by virtue of *utani* that the Bena and the Ngoni 'can enter each others' houses and demand food, and be as rude to each other as they like' (Culwicks, op. cit., p. 171). If a hut is shut and the owner is away an *mtani* can break in—even smash a padlock—prepare food, kill and eat a hen, help himself to any beer he finds. He is supposed to have two drinks on such an occasion, then place the dipper across the mouth of the beer-jar, so that his *mtani* on his return will know who has broken in (Ngoni). These rights hold good wherever the *watani* may find themselves, whether one of them is in his native country or both are in the area of a third tribe. Even making allowance for a difference between theory and practice, it is still at once apparent what an enormous help *utani* may be to men undertaking those month-long journeys to and from work which have been such a feature of Tanganyika life. *Watani* falling in with each other on the march pool their resources, mess together, and stick together in a quarrel.

Nearly all my informants have said that a person can ask from an *mtani* anything whatever that takes his fancy and that he may not be refused. A Sumbwa declared that if an *mtani* were refused, say, a hen, he could put a curse on your hens so that they all died of disease or were taken by hawks. In extreme cases, he could curse you so that you yourself would die. It is however generally understood that a small thing like a walking-stick, a hen, or even a goat, may usually be handed over without demur; to most of my informants it was unthinkable that it could be withheld; a

bigger thing, like a gun, is likely to be demanded only in order that it may be ransomed by the owner. The owner may plead: 'That is a very great thing. Don't ask for it and I will give you money to help you to buy one for yourself' (Yao). Even a wife may be the object in jocular demand (Kinga). But if the *mtani* really wants a thing he may refuse to allow the owner to ransom it or may set no less than the full market price upon it. Then there is no course open to the owner but to let it go and he has no legal redress. As an Ngoni puts it: 'A court would dismiss the case, for between *watani* there is no matter for law (*sheria*).' And a Nyakyusa: 'If you did get angry with an *mtani* to whom would you complain? The elders would know he was your *mtani* and would say "enough".' Even beer put out as *tambiko*, i.e. for the ancestral spirits, may be taken with impunity by an *mtani* (Sumbwa). This is, of course, logical on the basis that the *utani* ties of the beer-owner will also be binding on his ancestors.

In some tribes, but not in others, a man has a pre-emptive right to the daughter of an *mtani*. This seems most far-reaching in the Ngindo; a daughter asked for and spat on by an *mtani* may not be refused to him or she will die; and moreover the bride-price is remitted. Also among the Mbunga, Wemba, Nyakyusa, Sumbwa, and Kinga a father may not refuse his daughter to an *mtani*, but in the first four tribes the full bride-price can be demanded and in the last a part of it.

It seems to be generally held that in other affairs of life a man in difficulties, say for the means to pay a fine or to make up a bride-price, has no compelling claim on an *mtani*. Like any relative, he may or may not help him, as he feels disposed.

The functions of 'watani' in connexion with a funeral

When a death takes place any *mtani* of the deceased within reach is under at least as strong an obligation to attend as any relative; which helps to explain the number of unrelated people who apply for leave from an employer in order to go to funerals. Nyiramba *utani* ties confer the right to a cow on an *mtani* who puts in an appearance.

In some tribes an *mtani* is charged in preference to anyone else with the duty of breaking the news of an unexpected death. On the other hand among the Bondei when someone is told of the death of his *mtani* it is proper for him repeatedly and indignantly to deny that this is true, even after he has viewed the corpse. Dale (1896) probably had something of this sort in mind when he described the Bondei *mtani* as 'a jester who brightens up a mourning', but I suspect this interpretation.

In all the tribes investigated except the Chagga, and perhaps the Wemba, when a death has occurred the *watani* (or one selected *mtani*) have special functions at the funeral. They are often preferred to anyone else for the digging of the grave (Ha, Yao, Mbunga) or they mark it out (Digo). If a Nyakyusa has died in the bush and is 'far gone' when found, an *mtani* and no one else must prepare the body for burial. In these tribes and also in the Ngindo, Zigua, Zaramu, Nyiramba, Nyamwezi, Ngoni, and Kinga, there is the very remarkable custom that an *mtani* (male or female) should enter the open grave and lie down in it. Not until he has been fee'd with a shilling or two does he 'allow the dead man to be buried'. When satisfied, he stands up in the grave and receives the corpse. There are minor variations: the lying down is said to be only optional with Digo and Zigua; with the Zaramu not only the *mtani* who lies in the grave must be fee'd, but also a representative of each other *utani* tribe

represented at the funeral. Among the Sumbwa the *mtani* lies, not in the newly dug grave, but on the bed that is to be used as bier. Declaring that he must be buried along with the corpse, he will not vacate the bed so that the burial can proceed until he has been given money; and if he were to be refused another member of the family would die. These customs seem to have something in common with the obstruction of the funeral procession in the French Sudan (Paulme, *op. cit.*, p. 438). And it is possible that there is also some underlying connexion with the Bondei denial of the death cited above and the taunts of the Bemba *banungwe*, when the earth has been heaped above the corpse, that its relatives have buried a living man (Richards, *op. cit.*). All these customs have in common a ritual refusal by the *mtani* to recognize the necessity for the burying.

In general it appears that an *mtani* is preferred to any relative as master (or mistress) of ceremonies at a funeral. It is not clear how widely a female *mtani* is acceptable at a man's funeral. Among the Bondei she takes charge if no male *mtani* is available, but she sits apart and acts through a male go-between. The burial over, an *mtani* is required in nearly every tribe to shave the heads of the bereaved family. Among the Sumbwa he also breaks (so that it may not be used again) the stool on which the people have sat for the shaving. Among the Yao, if the deceased is a male a female *mtani* is called upon to do the shaving, and *vice versa*. As a rule the *mtani*, not a relative, is the deceased's executor, not only disposing of his property but, where a man has left a family, having to see them settled with a relative—cf. the statement by Richards (1937) that among the Bemba the *banungwe* are 'responsible for handing over to the heirs the insignia of inheritance'.

In all tribes the *watani* have a right to some share of the deceased's property, but many variants have been reported to me. With the Ngindo an *mtani* is said to have first call on anything he likes; with the Yao he is said to be entitled to a share of any money left, but not of goods; with the Nyamwezi the *mtani* is supposed to have at least the dead man's clothes and, if he left much property, a share of that as well. Among the Sambia an *mtani* takes the clothes ('the family would be afraid to wear them'), cooking-pots, and, if it is especially desired, his bed. One informant has suggested that it is a good thing for the cooking-pots to be removed so that the widow should have no chance of committing suicide by the ceremony of *vunja chungu* ('breaking the cooking-pot').¹

In many tribes the *watani* bring money (e.g. Digo, Nyakyusa, Nyamwezi, Kinga) or a beast (Ha, Mbunga, Ngoni) as a contribution to the funeral expenses, but it appears that in some cases (e.g. Zaramu) nearly as much in money, or an equivalent beast, is returned to the donor in the course of the ceremonies. Apart from this, in most tribes the *watani* have a right to some particular part of the animal that is slaughtered—the head and neck with the Yao, Mbunga, Zigua, Sambia, and Bondei, often with the skin as well. Sometimes a single *mtani* is entitled to a leg, while if several attend they have a right to a whole beast, which they slaughter themselves (Nyakyusa, Digo). It is sometimes specified that the *watani* should be served with meat before anyone else (Ngoni).

According to an Ngoni an *mtani* is charged, in preference to a relative, with the duty of looking after the grave mound and the tree (fig or *Cussonia*) that is planted as

¹ See *Tanganyika Notes and Records*, no. 12, pp. 49–50.

a monument. He is concerned to clear out the vermin, especially the zorilla polecats (*Ictonyx*), that are liable to make their homes in the mound; and no wood off the tree may be used without his permission. After a few visits he can claim a beast as his fee.

If the death has been due to a 'bad disease', nothing whatever of the deceased's property is supposed to be handled by relatives. In response to inquiry all informants quoted leprosy as *the* bad disease; additions were yaws (Mbunga, Zigua) and gangrenous sores (*kambako*, Bondei). In such cases an *mtani* takes charge of everything and normally burns it or throws it away in the uninhabited bush. A Bondei said that for this purpose the *mtani* is to the deceased's relatives as a European doctor is to ordinary people during a smallpox epidemic: he can expose himself to infection without danger.

The sanitary and magical functions of 'watani'

Fifty years ago, when the Bondei were mainly pagan, it was the duty of an *mtani* to kill off a family's *vigego* (unlucky children, such as those who cut their upper teeth before their lower), lepers, and 'people who were not wanted' (Dale, 1896). Modern Bondei are well aware of this; and one of them has remarked that a leper was removed 'when he was too long in dying'. When I told a Nyakyusa of these functions of the Bondei *mtani* he volunteered that exactly the same held good in his tribe; with the addition that the leper's body was not buried, but covered thickly by his *mtani* with branches of *mlangali* (candelabra *Euphorbia*). A Sumbwa gave a similar account; with his tribe, however, it was customary for a family to call in an *mtani* as soon as they detected any sign of leprosy in one of their number. The leper was then decoyed into the uninhabited bush and speared by the *mtani*. The corpse, like that of a yaws case, could not be buried but was merely covered with thorny branches. Among the Sumbwa also an *mtani* who had relieved a family from the danger of a *kigego* was rewarded by being given a child that became his absolute property. According to a Yao a leper has to be taken into the bush by his *watani*, to be looked after by them there—which may be a euphemism.

That tribes so dissimilar in origin and so remote geographically as the Bondei, the Sumbwa, and the Nyakyusa, should have given an *mtani* identical functions with regard to lepers and unlucky children suggests that he has been very widely empowered to undertake these measures of primitive sanitation.

An *mtani*, irrespective of sex or age, is also considered qualified above anyone else to help with certain minor physical ills, at least some of which are presumed to be punitive sanctions. Among the Zigua a person with mumps (*matumbwi*) seeks an *mtani*, who throws ashes over him. Among the Nyakyusa and Zaramu a stiff neck can be cured by an *mtani* who twists it once or twice to right and left. (An *mtani* is no use, however, to a Chagga with a stiff neck; he needs someone who is left-handed.) An *mtani* can benefit Nyakyusa boils and ringworm by spitting on them but cannot effect a cure 'unless God helps'. A Nyakyusa suffering from epileptic fits can apply to an *mtani*, who will provide medicine and charge him nothing. Among the Bondei a child who has broken a food-taboo (*mwiko*) is sent to an *mtani*. He applies a paste of sheep's dung and *mwengele*, which is said to be painful, and drives the patient home with blows and curses. (The remedy may well be effective: Mr. P. J. Greenway tells me that the plant is *Cissus adenocaulis*, with a juice so acid

that it is used for cleaning copper and brass.) Among the Bondei certain sores on the arms, said to be due to breach of a *mwiko*, are treated by an *mtani*, with ashes.

An ascription of quasi-magical powers to *watani* seems to underlie the curative functions just described. The idea became explicit in a Sumbwa statement: 'My *mtani* is in some sort my medicine man (*mtani wangu namna mganga wangu*).' He may cure a Sumbwa stiff neck by laying a string across a much-frequented path. When many people have passed over it the *mtani* takes it to the sufferer and ties it round his neck. As already mentioned, if a Sumbwa were to refuse an *mtani* something he wanted the *mtani* has power to curse to death; but it is also said that if he relents in time he can bring the patient back to health. The magical status of the *mtani*, at least in certain tribes, is most clearly shown by the fact that if a Sumbwa or Nyakyusa has before him a journey that he fears he can send for an *mtani* to *tambikia*, 'to intercede for him'. The *mtani* spits ceremonially and imprecates a whole series of evil things, in fact every likely disaster, to happen on the journey. Then the traveller sets out in full confidence that he will be safe from those dangers the *mtani* has specified. A Nyakyusa extended this 'going by opposites' to cases of serious illness, in which it was considered very helpful to the patient to call in an *mtani* to prophesy his early demise. 'I see you are soon going to die. It won't be long before I shall be burying you.' On the other hand it appears that the Ngoni accept as true a prophecy of disaster uttered by an *mtani*, for example, that on such-and-such a day some relative, perhaps many miles distant, will die; but it can be averted if the *mtani* accepts a few cents to unsay his words.

Dale, in describing Bondei ceremonies that are a prelude to a hunting expedition, mentions that the hunters' wives are given certain *miko* (taboos) to observe while their men are away, but refers to the *mtani* in this connexion only as making the response '*pepa*', i.e. 'Amen', to an invocation of the ancestors. According to the information given to me, however, the *mtani* was actually the master of these ceremonies. They are said to have been used only when dangerous game, especially buffalo, was expected and so must now be practically obsolete. But the *mtani* decapitated the fowl, from the behaviour of whose headless body auguries as to the behaviour of the game were drawn; he addressed the departing hunters with jesting exhortations not to be too great cowards; he invoked the ancestral spirits to ensure the hunters' safe return; and he it was who reminded the women of their various *miko* of the sympathetic magical type familiar in this connexion.¹

Conclusion

Only a beginning has been made with the mapping of the *utani* ties that bind tribe with tribe all through Tanganyika and beyond. Nor do we know how generally internal *utani* exists; its geographical distribution seems likely to be anomalous. The extent to which the customs connected with *utani* vary from tribe to tribe and the extent to which they are actually practised to-day would require prolonged investigation. Undoubtedly easier communications are breaking down the observances. As between the Chagga and the Pare the forfeit customs are said to be a thing of the past because intercourse is so frequent. Among the Bondei the 'joking' is obsolescent. It seems impossible that Zigua living on the main Turiani-Korogwe road could keep

¹ Frazer, J. G., *The Golden Bough*. Abridged ed., p. 23. London. 1925.

open house for the Nyamwezi, the Sukuma, the Kami, the Luguru, the Hehe, the Gogo, and the Zaramu who now pass in such numbers on their way to work on the sisal estates. And it is obvious that a place like Tanga market, with its admixture of tribes, would be in constant uproar if mutual recrimination, 'April fooling', and forfeiting went on with pristine vigour. Other Western influences must have a damping effect: the *mtani* cannot be called in to dispose of lepers and unlucky children so often as formerly; and missions tend to discourage buffoonery at weddings.

Nevertheless, the fact remains that, even as I have apprehended *utani*, dimly through the medium of men who are most of them expatriate, many of them Christianized, and none of them 'elders', the relationship is a reality throughout Tanganyika and a complicated conception full of apparent contradictions. Past enmity is cited as a necessary precursor of *utani*; yet its present exponents must show for each other a limitless tolerance. A man's *mtani* is his *alter ego*; between them nothing is to be resented and nothing refused, but they are under what is practically a ritual obligation to be constantly and flagrantly rude to each other. The selfsame person performs for him services that no one else can: disposes of his unwanted relatives, cures his ills for him, and, as in the forfeits, saves him from ill luck even when engendered by his own act. A man's *mtani* temporarily takes the place of his corpse in the grave; the *mtani* is preferred to any relative for the ritual shaving of the bereaved and often as executor also. These things would mark the *mtani* as closer than a brother; yet he is regarded as immune from infections that blood relatives greatly dread. Finally, cross an *mtani* and the rollicking leg-pulling fellow can become a sinister creature who is endowed with the power to imprecate the worst evils and whose words have the force of natural law.

POSTSCRIPT

The impression that *utani* is practically undocumented and has been generally overlooked in East Africa is confirmed by several friends of mine in the Tanganyika Administration who have been good enough to read the draft of this paper, and also by the terms of Professor A. R. Radcliffe-Brown's general theoretical discussion of joking relationships (*Africa*, vol. xiii, 195-210, 1940), which has since reached me.

The short contribution by T. V. Scrivenor in *Tanganyika Notes and Records*, no. 4, pp. 72-4 (1937), 'Some notes on *utani*, or the vituperative alliances between clans in the Masasi district', is packed with suggestive details. It should be read by anyone interested in the subject, and I am sorry that I did not have it before me when I wrote the foregoing. It deals with two groups for which I had no information, the Makua and the Tanganyika Yao. In point after point it agrees with what I had elicited for other tribes and it also brings out one duty of *watani* of which I had not heard: the investiture and initiation of the head of the clan having *utani* relations.

I am indebted to Mr. and Mrs. A. T. Culwick for suggestions and criticisms. Mrs. Culwick tells me that they now feel sure that the Bena *walongo* system as described in their book (1935) 'links up with (or is) *utani*'. She generously adds that 'the *utani* clue seems to throw much light on the Bena social system and whole organization of mutual help', which, when their book was being written, had seemed 'so indefinite in its organization and sanctions'.

Mr. T. M. Revington has been good enough to arrange for several Africans, who know

English, to read this paper. He tells me that they passed it as 'correct in every particular', though suggesting that 'of course civilized natives do not share in such foolishness'.

I am much indebted to Mr. J. T. A. Pearce for making independent inquiries at my instigation. He discussed the subject with Zigua, Sambaa, Nyamwezi, and Manyema—the recognition of *utani* by this last tribe extends the system into the Belgian Congo—and has told me that the information given him agreed, in detail as well as in general, with mine. A point of special interest is that he raised with the Amani subordinate court (Sambaa) the question of how they would deal with a complaint by a man against an *mtani* on account of an act, e.g. seizure of property, permitted by *utani*. The elders were unanimous that if the relationship between the parties were proved the court would not take cognizance of the complaint, whether the parties were both Sambaa or both members of alien tribes.

A summary of this article has already appeared in *Tanganyika Notes and Records*, no. 12, pp. 1-10, in which I included some further information relating to the Kami; the main points of this are: *a.* Father T. Schaegelen's demonstration that in this tribe 'internal *utani*' holds between second cousins as well as between clans; *b.* The existence of a relationship with the neighbouring Doe tribe, which, though called *utani*, is explicitly stated to have had its origin in mutual convenience.

More recently the Rev. E. Spies ('Observations on *utani* customs among the Ngoni of Songea District', *Tanganyika Notes and Records*, no. 16, pp. 49-53, 1943) has greatly amplified the information I had about this tribe, which may, I think, have been of special importance in the whole East African *utani* system.

Résumé

PARENTÉS À PLAISANTERIES EN TANGANYIKA

Outani est le nom d'un système de parenté à plaisanteries entre différentes tribus et parfois aussi entre familles et clans dans tout le territoire de Tanganyika. Ces parentés sont héréditaires, sans tenir compte de sexe ni d'âge. A l'origine de ces parentés sont des inimitiés parmi les ancêtres des *Ouatani*. Parmi les Ngoni — la seule tribu qui admette de nos jours la création d'un nouveau *Outani* — il est nécessaire d'avoir touché le cadavre au cours d'un ensevelissement pour participer.

La plaisanterie consiste à se taquiner mutuellement, à se jouer des tours, à se faire des poisons d'Avril, à s'imposer des gages. Ces gages semblent avoir le but d'enlever à leur possesseur certains objets qui pourraient porter malheur. Les membres de l'*Outani* ont droit à une hospitalité très étendue; ils peuvent réquisitionner de certains objets et même demander une femme. Tous les *Ouatani* doivent prendre part aux funérailles où ils s'acquittent de fonctions spéciales, telles que l'arrêt de la cérémonie par un participant qui se couche dans la fosse destinée à recevoir le mort. On préfère à un membre de la famille un *Mtani* comme exécuteur testamentaire et pour raser les têtes des proches parents. Les *Ouatani* en outre se chargent de certaines fonctions sanitaires et quasi magiques; ils tuent les enfants porte-malheurs et les lépreux et administrent les biens des lépreux au nom de la famille; ils guérissent certaines maladies et ils ont le pouvoir et le droit d'invoquer les bons et les mauvais esprits.